

AI CO-FOUNDER & GROWTH STRATEGY REPORT

Community-Supported Strategy

PrepPal AI — Impact First, Sustainability Second

MODEL

Community-Supported

STAGE

Pre-MVP

DATE

Jun 24, 2026

ADVISOR

AI Co-Founder

VALIDATE COMMUNITY

71/100

OVERALL READINESS

01 · STARTUP SUMMARY

Extracted from Day 22 + Day 23 Blueprints

DIMENSION	SUMMARY
Product	PrepPal AI — AI-powered mock interview & placement coaching platform for Indian campus placement. Text (v1) and voice (v2) mock interviews, real-time feedback, progress tracking, personalized prep plans.
Model	Community-supported platform (NOT SaaS). Core features free forever. Sustainability through donations, sponsors, partnerships, optional premium.
User	20-23 yr B.Tech students at tier-2/3 colleges entering campus placement season. 8M+ graduating annually.
Problem	75% of tier-2/3 students fail interviews due to poor communication. No India-native free AI coach exists.
MVP	Text-based mock interview engine (Claude/GPT-4 API) + India Q-bank (TCS/Infosys/Wipro) + scoring + session history.
Moat	NOT AI. Interview History + Progress Tracking + India Q-bank + Community Trust + Privacy-First.
GTM	Community-led: WhatsApp groups, LinkedIn, GitHub, campus ambassadors, challenge network. CAC = ~\$0.

02 · BUSINESS REALITY CHECK

Brutal Honesty Through Community Lens

QUESTION	ANSWER	CONFIDENCE
Who pays?	Nobody is required to pay. Donors, sponsors, partners, institutions fund sustainability.	MEDIUM
Why do they contribute?	Mission alignment, CSR budgets, brand visibility, alumni giving back.	LOW
How will users discover the product?	Community, GitHub, LinkedIn, WhatsApp, student referrals, challenge network.	LOW
Biggest growth risk?	Seasonal usage (placement season only), ChatGPT DIY competition, retention post-placement.	HIGH
Biggest sustainability risk?	Donation volatility, sponsor dependency, founder burnout, no paid team.	HIGH
Weak assumptions to validate?	User engagement, sponsor ROI, student advocacy, college partnership conversion.	CRITICAL

Validate Community Demand

CORE THESIS

PrepPal AI shows genuine demand signal and structural market gap. **The community-supported model is viable if adoption is validated before sustainability is assumed.**

PrepPal AI is not a SaaS startup. It is a community-supported educational platform — a category that includes **Wikipedia, Khan Academy, Linux, Firefox, and Blender**. These platforms didn't launch with subscription tiers. They optimised for impact first, sustainability second. PrepPal follows this model intentionally, targeting the 8M+ Indian students who enter campus placement annually — many of whom cannot afford paid tools.

DIMENSION	ASSESSMENT	SIGNAL
Problem Severity	Real, urgent, high-stakes — 75% of tier-2/3 students fail due to communication gaps	CRITICAL
Community Viability	Strong: college WhatsApp groups, build-in-public audience, challenge community — organic channels exist	STRONG
Sustainability	Honest risk: donations are volatile. Institutional partnerships and CSR sponsorships are the most reliable streams.	MODERATE
Market Gap	No India-native, free AI interview coach exists. Structural gap, not a temporary one.	CONFIRMED
Founder-Mission Fit	Founder is the user. Built a privacy intelligence dashboard. Lives the problem daily. 7.8/10.	STRONG
Validation Status	Pre-MVP. Informal signal only. First 100 users sprint is the critical next step.	EARLY
Impact Potential	8M students/year. Even 1% adoption = 80,000 users. Placement success = life-changing outcome for families.	MASSIVE

04 · FOUNDER FEEDBACK INTEGRATION

Corrected Sequence — Users Before Sponsors

FOUNDER'S CORRECTION (VERBATIM INTENT)

"The report is good — but it gets too excited about CSR and grants too early. Nobody funds a platform because it sounds nice. They fund it because 500 users, 1,000 users, 5,000 users exist. CSR is a Month 6 problem. Right now the sequence is: **Users** → **Retention** → **Success Stories** → **Community** → **Then sponsors**."

✓ WHAT V1 GOT RIGHT

- ✓ **Moat identification:** Correctly identified that the moat is NOT the AI — it's Interview History, Progress Tracking, India Q-Bank, Community Trust, Privacy-First.
- ✓ **GTM channels:** WhatsApp groups, LinkedIn build-in-public, GitHub, campus ambassadors — all realistic, zero-cost, available today.
- ✓ **Honest threats:** ChatGPT DIY competition, seasonal placement cycles, solo-founder execution risk, donation volatility — all correctly flagged.
- ✓ **Core verdict:** "Build the text MVP. Get 100 active users. Capture 5 success stories. Then approach sponsors." — this line IS the strategy.
- ✓ **No fake pricing:** Correctly deprecated ₹199/₹499/₹999 tiers. Community-supported model framed accurately.

✗ WHAT V1 GOT WRONG — CORRECTED

- ✗ **CSR too early:** v1 listed "Draft your 1-page CSR impact deck" as a Week 2 action. Wrong. CSR requires proof: 500+ users, measurable outcomes, success stories. Revisit at Month 4-6.
- ✗ **Grants too prominent:** v1 put grants (DST/MEITY/Nasscom) in Week 3. Grant applications take 3-6 months and require user traction data. Month 6-12 activity.
- ✗ **Wrong sequence:** v1 implied: Prototype → CSR/Grants → Users. Backwards. Correct: MVP → 100 Users → Retention → Success Stories → Community → Sponsors/Grants.
- ✗ **Sustainability overconfidence:** v1 gave external sustainability streams "MEDIUM" reliability too optimistically. College partnerships and CSR deals require 6+ months of relationship-building. Honest re-rating: LOW reliability before 500 users.

THE CORRECTED OPERATING SEQUENCE

This is the single most important correction in this report. Everything else — CSR, grants, college partnerships, sponsorships — is downstream of this sequence.

STEP 1 · NOW

Working Text MVP

Build text-based mock interview using Claude/GPT-4 API. Deploy free on Vercel. Only job right now.

STEP 2 · WEEK 2-3

100 Active Users

Not signups. Not views. 100 students who completed at least 1 full mock session. Session completion > 65%.

STEP 3 · WEEK 3-4

50 Returning Users

Day-7 retention > 30%. Students who came back for a second session. This is PMF signal.

STEP 4 · MONTH 2

5 Success Stories

"I practiced on PrepPal and got placed at TCS." 5 real stories with names. Entire sales pitch for every future conversation.

STEP 5 · MONTH 3+

Community → Sponsors

ONLY NOW approach colleges, CSR teams, grant bodies. Walk in with data: 100+ users, 50 returning, 5 placed.

NORTH STAR METRIC — NEXT 30 DAYS

Sessions completed by real humans. Not strategy docs. Not CSR decks. Not grant applications. 100 sessions. 50 returning users. 5 placement stories. Everything else is secondary.

05 · BUSINESS MODEL CANVAS

Community Edition — Adapted 9-Block BMC

Adapted from Osterwalder's 9-block BMC for a community-supported platform. Revenue streams are secondary to mission and adoption.

KEY PARTNERS

- ▶ College placement cells (tier-2/3)
- ▶ IT companies with CSR budgets (TCS, Infosys, Wipro)
- ▶ Alumni networks (IIT/NIT grads giving back)
- ▶ AI API providers (Anthropic, OpenAI — startup credits)
- ▶ Open-source contributors

KEY ACTIVITIES

- ▶ Build & maintain text-based mock interview engine
- ▶ Curate India-specific company Q-banks
- ▶ Community management (WhatsApp, LinkedIn, GitHub)
- ▶ Session feedback report generation
- ▶ Privacy-first data architecture

VALUE PROPOSITION

- ▶ FREE, realistic mock interviews for Indian placement
- ▶ Company-specific Q-banks (TCS, Infosys, Wipro, Amazon)
- ▶ Real-time content + communication scoring
- ▶ Interview History & Progress Tracking
- ▶ Privacy-first: auto-delete 30 days

CUSTOMER RELATIONSHIPS

- ▶ Build-in-public transparency
- ▶ Community Discord / WhatsApp
- ▶ Open-source GitHub engagement
- ▶ College ambassador program
- ▶ Personal onboarding for first 100 users

CHANNELS

- ▶ College WhatsApp groups (primary)
- ▶ LinkedIn build-in-public posts
- ▶ GitHub open-source repo
- ▶ Challenge community (ABTalks)
- ▶ Word-of-mouth from placed students

CUSTOMER SEGMENTS

- ▶ Primary: Tier-2/3 engineering students (free)
- ▶ Secondary: Working professionals (free + optional premium)
- ▶ Funders: CSR budgets, impact investors, grant bodies
- ▶ Institutional: College placement cells (B2B later)

COST STRUCTURE

- ▶ AI API calls (Claude/GPT-4): ~₹15K-25K/mo at scale
- ▶ Hosting (Vercel free tier → paid): ₹0-2K/mo
- ▶ Domain + email: ₹2K/yr
- ▶ Founder time: 100% (solo, unpaid)
- ▶ Total monthly burn: ~₹17-27K (mostly API)

REVENUE STREAMS

- ▶ Voluntary donations (Buy Me a Coffee, UPI)
- ▶ CSR sponsorships (Month 6-12)
- ▶ Institutional partnerships (Month 6-12)
- ▶ Optional premium features (non-gating)
- ▶ API startup credits (near-term lever)

MISSION (COMMUNITY ADDITION)

- ▶ Maximize accessibility for Indian students
- ▶ Never gate core features behind paywall
- ▶ Impact > Revenue at this stage
- ▶ Sustainability through community support
- ▶ Reference: Wikipedia, Khan Academy, Linux

Adoption First — Sustainability Second

FRAMING

Revenue is not the primary objective of the initial MVP. The focus is adoption, feedback, and accessibility. Sustainability is expected through community support, sponsorships, partnerships, and optional premium offerings that do not restrict access to core features.

STREAM	TIMELINE	RELIABILITY	NOTES
API Startup Credits	Month 1	HIGH	Anthropic, OpenAI, Vercel startup programs. Apply immediately. Covers 80% of near-term costs.
Optional Premium	Month 3-6	MEDIUM	Non-gating features: detailed analytics, custom company packs, priority processing. Core stays free.
Voluntary Donations	Month 3+	LOW	Buy Me a Coffee, UPI. Realistic: ₹2-5K/mo. Placed students giving back. Honest expectation: minimal.
CSR Sponsorships	Month 6-12	LOW	Requires 500+ users + measurable outcomes. TCS Foundation, Infosys Foundation, Wipro Cares. 3-6 month cycle.
Institutional Partnerships	Month 6-12	LOW	College placement cells paying for bulk access. Requires proven retention data first.
Grants	Month 6-12	LOW	DST, MEITY, Nasscom Foundation, IndiaAI. 3-6 month application cycle. Needs user traction data.

COST REALITY

Monthly Burn at Various Stages

STAGE	USERS	API CALLS	HOSTING	TOTAL BURN
Pre-launch	0	₹0 (free tier)	₹0 (Vercel free)	₹0/mo
100 users	100 active	₹8-12K	₹0-500	₹8-12K/mo
500 users	500 active	₹20-30K	₹1-2K	₹21-32K/mo
1,000 users	1,000 active	₹40-60K	₹2-3K	₹42-63K/mo

HONEST ASSESSMENT

At 1,000 users, monthly burn hits ₹42-63K — beyond solo-founder sustainability without sponsors. **This is why the corrected sequence matters:** sponsors must be approached at Month 3+ with traction data, not Month 1 with a pitch deck.

07 · GO-TO-MARKET STRATEGY

Community-Led Growth — 4 Phases

PHASE	TIMELINE	FOCUS	EXIT METRIC
1. Seed	Week 1-2	Direct outreach: 20 college WhatsApp groups, personal LinkedIn network, challenge community	50 signups
2. Prove Value	Week 3-4	Deliver 100 mock sessions, collect feedback, refine scoring, publish "built this week" updates	100 sessions, 30% return
3. Community Infrastructure	Month 2-3	Launch Discord, recruit 3-5 campus ambassadors, open-source the Q-bank on GitHub	500 users, 5 ambassadors
4. Institutional	Month 4-6	Approach college placement cells with traction data. Begin CSR conversations with proof.	2 college partnerships

08 · USER ACQUISITION STRATEGY

CAC = ~\$0 — Community-Sourced

CHANNEL	WEEKLY REACH	CAC	CONVERSION LOGIC
College WhatsApp Groups	30-100	₹0	Direct peer referral. "Free AI mock for TCS prep" → 5-10% click → 2-3% signup
LinkedIn Build-in-Public	50-200	₹0	Founder posts weekly progress. Audience grows organically. 1-2% → signup
GitHub Open Source	10-30	₹0	Q-bank repo attracts technical students. Credibility signal. 3-5% → try the product
Placed Student WOM	5-20	₹0	"I got placed at TCS using PrepPal" → highest-converting channel. 10-15% → signup
Challenge Community	20-50	₹0	ABTalks 60-day challenge network. Mutual support. 2-4% → signup

WHY CAC = \$0 WORKS

Traditional SaaS needs ₹500-2000 CAC. PrepPal's community model leverages existing student networks where the product spreads because **placement success is inherently shareable**. One placed student = 5-10 referrals. This is the viral loop.

09 · FIRST 100 USERS PLAN

30-Day Sprint — Active Users, Not Signups

WEEK	ACTION	TARGET
Week 1	DM 50 engineering students in your network. Post in 10 college WhatsApp groups. Offer free TCS mock interview.	30 signups, 15 sessions
Week 2	Refine scoring based on feedback. LinkedIn post: "Built an AI mock interview — 15 students tried it, here's what I learned." Tag ABTalks.	50 signups, 40 sessions
Week 3	Recruit 2 campus ambassadors (VIT Bhopal, your own college). Open-source Q-bank on GitHub. Run a "TCS placement challenge."	75 signups, 70 sessions
Week 4	Publish first success story (even informal). Ask 5 users for video testimonials. Apply for Anthropic + Vercel startup credits.	100 signups, 100 sessions

10 · COMPETITIVE POSITION & COMMUNITY MOAT

The Moat Is NOT AI — It's Data + Trust

CRITICAL INSIGHT

Everyone has AI. ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini — all free, all capable. **The moat cannot be "we use AI."** The moat is what AI alone cannot replicate.

THE REAL MOAT

- ✓ **Interview History:** 100+ sessions per user showing progress over time. ChatGPT has no memory of past interviews.
- ✓ **Assessment Reports:** Structured scoring (Relevance + Clarity + STAR). Generic AI gives generic feedback.
- ✓ **Placement Readiness Tracking:** "You're 70% ready for TCS, 45% ready for Amazon." No competitor offers this.
- ✓ **Personalized Improvement Plans:** Data-driven "focus next on: behavioral rounds." Requires session history.
- ✓ **Community Trust:** India-first, privacy-first, free-forever. Built by a student, for students.
- ✓ **India-First Q-Bank:** TCS NQT, Infosys InfyTQ, Wipro patterns. US tools (Yoodli, Pramp) don't have this.

COMPETITIVE THREATS

- ✗ **ChatGPT DIY:** Students prompt "interview me for TCS." Works for content, lacks structure + tracking + scoring.
- ✗ **Yoodli:** US-centric voice AI. ₹2,000/mo. No India Q-bank. Not accessible to tier-2/3 students.
- ✗ **InterviewBit:** DSA-only. Doesn't cover HR/behavioral rounds. No voice, no communication feedback.
- ✗ **Unacademy / upGrad:** Could launch a competing feature. Moat = speed + community trust + India Q-bank depth.
- ✗ **Peer mock interviews:** Free but cancel 70% of the time. No structured feedback.

11 • REVERSE SWOT ANALYSIS

Threats & Weaknesses First — Then Strengths

Reverse SWOT leads with Threats and Weaknesses because for a pre-MVP community project, these are more actionable than Strengths and Opportunities.

● THREATS (EXTERNAL)

- **ChatGPT DIY:** Students use free ChatGPT for mock interviews. No moat unless we offer structure + tracking + scoring.
- **Seasonal usage:** Placement season = Aug-Mar. Apr-Jul = dead zone. Working professional segment must offset.
- **Donation volatility:** Community-supported = unpredictable revenue. One bad month = founder can't sustain.
- **Large player entry:** Unacademy/upGrad could copy in 3 months. Speed + community trust = only defense.
- **AI API cost spikes:** Claude/GPT-4 pricing changes could break the unit economics.
- **Retention post-placement:** Students who get placed have no reason to return. One-shot usage.

● WEAKNESSES (INTERNAL)

- **Solo founder:** No technical co-founder. Execution bottleneck. Single point of failure.
- **No paying users:** Pre-MVP. No revenue validation. Sustainability is theoretical.
- **No team:** Community management, content creation, coding — all on one person.
- **Limited runway:** Self-funded. API costs scale with users. No buffer for mistakes.
- **No brand authority:** Unknown. No testimonials, no placed students yet.
- **Voice AI deferred:** v1 is text-only. Competitors offer voice. Technical risk for v2.

● STRENGTHS (INTERNAL)

- **Founder-market fit:** 7.8/10. Founder is the user. Lives the problem daily.
- **Privacy-first architecture:** Auto-delete 30 days. Differentiator vs. data-hungry competitors.
- **Build-in-public momentum:** Day 22-24 challenge posts. Audience growing.
- **Zero CAC GTM:** WhatsApp + LinkedIn + GitHub = free distribution.
- **India-first Q-bank:** TCS/Infosys/Wipro patterns. No direct competitor has this.

● OPPORTUNITIES (EXTERNAL)

- **8M students/year:** Massive market. Even 0.1% = 8,000 users.
- **No India-native free AI coach:** Structural gap. First-mover advantage available.
- **CSR budgets:** TCS Foundation, Infosys Foundation. Month 6-12 lever.
- **Government grants:** DST, MEITY, IndiaAI. Month 6-12 lever.
- **Challenge community:** ABTalks network = free beta testers + advocates.

12 · INVESTMENT SCORECARD

Community Lens — Not VC Metrics

78

COMMUNITY VIABILITY

55

SUSTAINABILITY

74

GTM STRENGTH

82

COMPETITIVE

68

FUNDER READINESS

DIMENSION	SCORE	REASONING	KEY ACTION
Community Viability	78	Strong organic channels (WhatsApp, LinkedIn, GitHub). Build-in-public audience already exists. Mission resonates with every Indian student.	Hit 100 active users in 30 days — this is the community proof point.
Sustainability	55	Honest risk: donations from students are minimal. Grants take 6-12 months. API credits are the only near-term lever. Sustainability is a Month 6-12 problem.	Apply for API startup credits (Anthropic, OpenAI, Vercel) immediately.
GTM Strength	74	Organic channels exist and are proven. CAC = ~\$0. WhatsApp + LinkedIn + GitHub = free distribution. Placed student WOM is the viral loop.	Execute the 4-phase GTM plan. Recruit 2 campus ambassadors in Week 3.
Competitive Strength	82	Moat is defensible if built quickly — user data + community trust + India-first Q-bank. No direct India-native free AI competitor exists.	Build the Q-bank moat NOW. 30 TCS + 30 Infosys + 30 Wipro questions by Week 2.
Funder Readiness	68	Impact narrative strong. Reference models (Wikipedia, Khan Academy) credible. But need user data first. No funder backs a pre-MVP community project without traction.	Get 100 users + 5 success stories before approaching any funder.

OVERALL SCORE: 71/100 – VERDICT: ● VALIDATE COMMUNITY

The community-supported model is viable **if adoption is validated before sustainability is assumed**. Sustainability scores low (55) — and that's the honest tradeoff of the community model. It's okay. Impact > Revenue at this stage.

For Impact Investors / CSR / Grants

IMPACT INVESTOR / CSR / GRANT ONE-LINER

"Free AI mock interview coaching for 8M Indian students — community-supported, privacy-first, built by a student who lived the problem."

30-SECOND FOUNDER PITCH

Mission-First, Sustainability-Second

SECTION	PITCH
Hook	75% of tier-2/3 Indian students fail their first interview — not because they don't know the answers, but because they've never practiced under pressure.
Problem	YouTube is passive. Peer mocks cancel 70% of the time. ChatGPT doesn't know what TCS actually asks. 8M students enter placement season unpracticed every year.
Solution	PrepPal AI — free, company-specific AI mock interviews with real-time feedback, progress tracking, and personalized prep plans.
Model	Community-supported. Free forever. Like Wikipedia or Khan Academy. Sustainability through donations, CSR sponsorships, and optional premium — never gating core features.
Ask	Not money — users. 100 active students in the next 30 days. If they love it, sustainability follows. If they don't, no amount of funding fixes that.

Top 10 Next Actions — Resequenced

TODAY	Apply for Anthropic, OpenAI, and Vercel startup credits. This covers 80% of near-term API costs. Free money exists — go get it.
DAY 2-3	Set up GitHub repo. Open-source the Q-bank structure (TCS/Infosys/Wipro). Push the first 10 sample questions. Credibility signal for technical students.
DAY 3-5	DM 30 engineering students in your college network. Offer a free TCS mock interview. Goal: 10 sessions completed by Day 5.
WEEK 2	Build the text-based MVP on Vercel. Use Claude/GPT-4 API. 30 TCS + 30 Infosys questions. Scoring: Relevance + Clarity + STAR. Deploy free.
WEEK 2	Post in 10 college WhatsApp groups: "Free AI mock interview for TCS placement — no signup, no card." Measure clicks → signups → sessions.
WEEK 3	LinkedIn build-in-public post: "Built an AI mock interview — 30 students tried it, here's what I learned." Tag @Anthropic @ABTalksOnAI. This is free distribution.
WEEK 3	Recruit 2 campus ambassadors (your college + VIT Bhopal). Offer LinkedIn badge + resume credit. They bring 20-40 users each.
WEEK 4	Collect 5 success stories (even informal: "practiced 3x, felt confident, got placed"). These are your entire sales pitch for Month 3+ conversations.
MONTH 2	Begin grant research (DST, MEITY, Nasscom Foundation). Do NOT apply yet — just map deadlines + requirements. Applications are Month 4-6.
MONTH 3+	ONLY NOW: approach college placement cells with traction data (100+ users, 50 returning, 5 placed). Begin CSR conversations with proof, not pitch decks.

15 · VISUAL DASHBOARD

Community Platform Overview

BUSINESS MODEL

- ▶ Community-supported platform (NOT SaaS)
- ▶ Core features free forever
- ▶ Impact first, sustainability second
- ▶ Reference: Wikipedia, Khan Academy

SUSTAINABILITY STREAMS

- ▶ API credits (Month 1 — High reliability)
- ▶ Optional premium (Month 3-6 — Medium)
- ▶ Donations (Month 3+ — Low)
- ▶ CSR / Grants (Month 6-12 — Low)

GTM FLOW

- ▶ Seed: WhatsApp + LinkedIn (Week 1-2)
- ▶ Prove: 100 sessions (Week 3-4)
- ▶ Infrastructure: Ambassadors + GitHub (Month 2-3)
- ▶ Institutional: College partnerships (Month 4-6)

FIRST 100 USERS

- ▶ Week 1: 30 signups (DM network)
- ▶ Week 2: 50 signups (WhatsApp groups)
- ▶ Week 3: 75 signups (ambassadors)
- ▶ Week 4: 100 signups + 100 sessions

COMMUNITY MOAT

- ▶ Interview History (per-user progress)
- ▶ Assessment Reports (structured scoring)
- ▶ Placement Readiness Tracking
- ▶ India-first Q-bank (TCS/Infosys/Wipro)
- ▶ Community trust + privacy-first

KEY RISKS

- ▶ ChatGPT DIY competition (HIGH)
- ▶ Seasonal usage — placement only (HIGH)
- ▶ Donation volatility (HIGH)
- ▶ Solo founder execution (HIGH)
- ▶ Retention post-placement (MEDIUM)

SCORE CARDS & VERDICT

5 Scores → Overall 71/100

78

VIABILITY

55

SUSTAIN.

74

GTM

82

COMPETITIVE

68

FUNDER

FINAL VERDICT:  **VALIDATE COMMUNITY**

Overall Score: 71/100 — The community-supported model is viable if adoption is validated before sustainability is assumed. Build the MVP. Get 100 users. Capture 5 success stories. Then approach sponsors.

SUSTAINABILITY VERDICT



VALIDATE COMMUNITY

PrepPal AI is being developed as a community-supported platform rather than a traditional SaaS product. The objective is maximizing accessibility for Indian students — many of whom cannot afford paid tools — while exploring sustainable funding mechanisms including donations, CSR sponsorships, institutional partnerships, grants, and optional premium offerings that do not restrict access to core features.

"The community-supported model is viable if adoption is validated before sustainability is assumed."

Build the text MVP. Talk to 100 users. Capture 5 success stories. Then approach sponsors.